

Test cricket, the lowest in any decade since the 1960s.

Central to this struggle has been a growing rigidity in approach. This includes a reluctance to sweep and a curtailment of down-the-track footwork as a defensive option.

Indian batters since the turn of the decade have used the slog, reverse and conventional sweeps against only 3.6 per cent of all spin deliveries faced in Tests. Only Afghanistan fares worse on this metric.

When it comes to stepping down the pitch, there has been a dramatic shift in India's approach post-Pujara. The former No.3 was a master of using his feet to defend and rotate strike against spin.

Pujara stepped out of his crease against 21.5 per cent of all spin deliveries he faced in Tests. Only 33.7 per cent of those resulted in attacking shots. But since his last Test in 2023, India has embraced a brasher tone: 69.4 per cent of all down-the-track shots played against spin have been aggressive.

The value of adding a defensive tint to this technique was visible in the batting of Tristan Stubbs, the highest scorer of the series.

Stubbs used his reach to good effect, constantly jumping out of his crease to block the spinners or

nudge them for singles. This allowed him to work the field more effectively while disrupting line and length.

This was part of a broader judiciousness in footwork that South Africa displayed through the series.

South Africa played 32.3 per cent of all spin deliveries off the back foot, compared to India's 29.6. When the Proteas batters went back, they averaged 66.66, as against 23.87 when coming forward.

Indian batters were far more tentative in their footwork, often getting caught in between, particularly when dip and drift came into play. They averaged just 14.25 off the front foot against spin, while the back-foot average was 13.87.

Selection bias

Adding to the fragility of the current Indian batting line-up has been head coach Gautam Gambhir's fixation with all-rounders.

Gambhir has often gone out of his way to accommodate all-rounders in his Test XIs, sometimes at the cost of specialist batters. In both Tests against South Africa, India picked three all-rounders along with two keeper-batters in Pant and Dhruv Jurel.

In Kolkata, India even promoted spin all-rounder Washington to No.3 at the expense of B. Sai Sudharsan.

In Guwahati, Sai Sudharsan

returned to the XI along with pace all-rounder Nitish Kumar Reddy, who failed to make an impact with either bat or ball.

The self-inflicted damage extends to India's batting pool. Sarfaraz Khan, who forced his way into the Test team with stellar domestic form, has fallen out of favour. Another in-form domestic batter, Karun Nair, received only a handful of opportunities in England before being sidelined.

Despite a recent dip in form, Sarfaraz still owns a First-Class average of 63.15. Karun has continued to pile on runs in domestic cricket, scoring 602 from just five matches in the ongoing Ranji Trophy season.

The India A side, long an established route into Test cricket, is now being used largely to provide match time to fringe players from the main squad. India A's playing XI for its second match against South Africa in the lead-up to the Test series had nine Test regulars.

Structural drift

While it would be difficult to isolate a single root cause for India's dual decline against spin, batting coach Sitanshu Kotak suggested it could be an outcome of the country's recent fascination with fast bowling.

"This is one thing I have observed in the last five years, happening all over India. It is that we have been playing more First-Class cricket on green wickets, trying to bring the fast bowlers into the game for the first two days," said Kotak ahead of the Guwahati Test.

"Spin comes into play, maybe on the third day. Because of this, there has been an increase in the role of the fast bowlers. If you keep the grass [like that], the ball will not spin as much as you expect," he added.

With domestic pitches tilting towards pacers in recent years, a simultaneous decline in both the quality of spin bowling and the ability to bat against spin was perhaps inevitable.

The one thing in India's favour is time. The side's next home Test assignment is not until early 2027, against Australia. It is now up to the team management to find solutions.

India's home series defeats

Team/Series	Matches	Won	Lost	Draw
England in India Test Series, 1933/34	3	0	2	1
Australia in India Test Series, 1956/57	3	0	2	1
West Indies in India Test Series, 1958/59	5	0	3	2
Australia in India Test Series, 1959/60	5	1	2	2
West Indies in India Test Series, 1966/67	3	0	2	1
Australia in India Test Series, 1969/70	5	1	3	1
West Indies in India Test Series, 1974/75	5	2	3	0
England in India Test Series, 1976/77	5	1	3	1
Golden Jubilee Test (England in India), 1979/80	1	0	1	0
West Indies in India Test Series, 1983/84	6	0	3	3
England in India Test Series, 1984/85	5	1	2	2
Pakistan in India Test Series, 1986/87	5	0	1	4
South Africa in India Test Series, 1999/00	2	0	2	0
Border-Gavaskar Trophy (Australia in India), 2004/05	4	1	2	1
England in India Test Series, 2012/13	4	1	2	1
New Zealand in India Test Series, 2024/25	3	0	3	0
Freedom Trophy (South Africa in India), 2025/26	2	0	2	0